approach toward India. The jihadi groups opposed this rapprochement vehemently.[68] When Sharif met Indian PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee on the sidelines of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation [SAARC] summit during the summer of 1998 he proposed reducing tensions. In November 1998 both countries agreed to resume passenger bus services across the border, with Vajpayee pledging to ride the first bus to Lahore. In February 1999 he made good on that pledge, and during his visit the two countries signed the Lahore Declaration. Among other things, this stipulated that the two countries would 'intensify their efforts to resolve all issues, including the issue of Jammu & Kashmir,' as well as 'reaf-firm their condemnation of terrorism in all its forms and manifestations and their determination to combat this menace.'[69]

Three months later the burgeoning peace process crashed to a halt after Pakistani troops executed a daring incursion into Indian-controlled territory. The army's infiltration into the Kargil district high up in the Himalayas was already well advanced in terms of planning at the time the Lahore Declaration was signed.[70] The official Pakistani storyline about the Kargil conflict, which took place between May and July 1999, was that militants who were intent on liberating Indian-administered Kashmir launched the offensive. Numerous authors have since debunked this myth, including then Chief of Army Staff Pervez Musharraf who orchestrated what was very much a Pakistani military operation.[71] According to some estimates, militants only accounted for approximately 10 per cent of the forces that crossed the LoC and occupied the Kargil district.[72] Among the militant outfits that were involved, Lashkar claimed 'pride of place.'[73] Initially, the operation was a tactical success and the Indian army was caught off guard. But New Delhi soon responded with a massive counter-offensive. The third India-Pakistan war fought over Kashmir was underway. By the end of June 1999, the Pakistan army was looking for an exit strategy. Whether Sharif was aware of initial plans for the invasion remains a subject of debate, but in early July he traveled to Washington, DC to meet with US President Bill Clinton and agreed to a diplomatic solution. Though Clinton would not promise to mediate an end to the Kashmir conflict, he did pledge to take a personal interest in intensifying peace talks if the LoC could be respected.[74] This paved the way for a Pakistani withdrawal.